Slide 1

Introduction to Vicarious Trauma

Adapted from the *Introduction to Vicarious Trauma for Law Enforcement*

Slide 2

"The expectation that we can be immersed in suffering and loss daily and not be touched by it is as unrealistic as expecting to be able to walk through water without getting wet."

(Remen, 2006)

Slide 3

- Stress
  - Acute
  - Chronic
- Traumatic stress

- Vicarious trauma
- Critical incident stress
- Vicarious traumatization
- Secondary traumatic stress
- Compassion fatigue
- Burnout

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Slide 4

Stress

Slide 5

The Stress Response

The brain and body's alarmed and alert response to a threatening situation.

Integral to the life of every living organism.

Our natural defense against danger.

Slide 6

Cumulative Stress

Cumulative stress reactions are more gradual form of stress reaction. Related to chronic stressors that "pile up" over time

Slide 7

Taking a Closer Look…

- Trauma
- Traumatic stress
- Vicarious traumatization

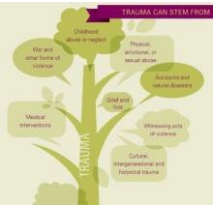
Slide 8

Human
Homicide
Sexual Assault
Assault/attack
War

Natural
Hurricane
Earthquake
Flood
Fire

On the Job
Fight or physical attack
Threat of physical harm
Accident

Traumatic Events



Slide 9

Trauma

- **Trauma** is an event that is outside one's normal experience that causes intense fear and can exceed one's ability to cope.
- A traumatic event is more than a stressor; it is a threat to one's safety, security, and sense of well-being.
- Traumatic Events occur as:
  - A result of people's behaviours or actions
  - Accidents
  - Natural Occurrences (tornados, hurricane, earthquake etc.)
- Exposure happens:
  - Directly – being involved in a critical incident
  - Indirectly – witnessing the traumatic experiences of another person

Slide 10

What Makes an Event Traumatic?

- It involves a threat—real or perceived—to one's physical or emotional well-being.
- It is overwhelming.
- It results in intense feelings of fear and lack of control.
- It leaves one feeling helpless.
- It changes the way a person understands the world, themselves, and others.

(American Psychiatric Association, 2000)

Slide 11

Defining Traumatic Stress

Traumatic stress is the stress response to a traumatic event(s) in which one is a victim or witness.

- Repeated stressful and/or traumatic events can chronically elevate the body's stress response.
- 4 percent of victims suffer about 44 percent of the offenses.

(Farrell and Pease, 1993)

Slide 12

Understanding the Difference Between Traumatic Stress and Vicarious Traumatization

Traumatic Stress	Vicarious Traumatization
• Extreme emotionality or absence of emotion	• Overly involved with or avoidance of victim/survivor
• Fearful, jumpy, exaggerated startle response	• Hypervigilance and fear for one's own safety (the world no longer feels safe and people can't be trusted)
• Flashbacks	• Intrusive thoughts and images, or nightmares from victims' stories

Slide 13

Work-Related Trauma Exposure

DIRECT exposure to trauma

- Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Post Traumatic Stress Symptoms
- Critical Incident Stress

INDIRECT exposure to trauma

- Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (DSM-V, 2013)
- Post Traumatic Stress Symptoms
- Empathic Strain
- Secondary Traumatic Stress Symptoms
- Vicarious Traumatization
- Compassion Fatigue

Slide 14

Change in World View

- Exposure to vicarious trauma leads to a change in world view. This is considered to be the result of **cumulative** exposure to traumatic stimuli.
- Empathy and empathic engagement with victims of trauma is a necessary skill we utilize to form connections, create a sense of safety, and express understanding to the people we help
  - Empathy is a good thing except it can shift our view of the world – depending on our initial view of the world the shift may be more or less profound
  - Our work experiences can challenge the belief that the world is relatively safe and predictable and people are good – we see how cruel people can be to each other

Slide 15

It's the shift in how we view the world, view others, and sense danger around us…

Slide 16

Secondary Traumatic Stress (STS)

"…the natural consequent behaviors and emotions resulting from knowing about a traumatizing event experienced by another…the stress resulting from helping or wanting to help a traumatized or suffering person."

(Figley, 1995)

Slide 17

Compassion Fatigue

"A combination of physical, emotional, and spiritual depletion associated with caring for patients in significant emotional pain and physical distress."

(Anewalt, 2009; Figley, 1995)

Slide 18

What About Burnout?

Burnout is "a state of physical, emotional, and mental exhaustion caused by long-term involvement in emotionally demanding situations."

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Examples of Vicarious Traumatization: Personal

- Physical
  - Rapid pulse/breathing, headaches, impaired immune system, fatigue, aches
- Emotional
  - Feelings of powerlessness, numbness, anxiety, guilt, fear, anger, depletion, hypersensitivity, sadness, helplessness, severe emotional distress or physical reactions to reminders
- Behavioral
  - Irritability, sleep and appetite changes, isolate from friends and family, self destructive behavior, impatience, nightmares, hypervigilance, moody, easily startled or frightened
- Spiritual
  - Loss of purpose, loss of meaning, questioning goodness versus evil, disillusionment, questioning prior religious beliefs, pervasive hopelessness
- Cognitive
  - Diminished concentration, cynicism, pessimism, preoccupation with clients, traumatic imagery, inattention, self doubt, racing thoughts, recurrent and unwanted distressing thoughts
- Relational
  - Withdrawn, decreased interest in intimacy or sex, isolation from friends or family, minimization of others' concerns, projection of anger or blame, intolerance, mistrust

(Adapted from J. Yassen in Figley, 1995)

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Examples of Vicarious Traumatization: Professional

- Performance
  - Decrease in quality/quantity of work, low motivation, task avoidance or obsession with detail, working too hard, setting perfectionist standards, difficulty with inattention, forgetfulness
- Morale
  - Decrease in confidence, decrease in interest, negative attitude, apathy, dissatisfaction, demoralization, feeling undervalued and unappreciated, disconnected, reduced compassion
- Relational
  - Detached/withdrawn from co-workers, poor communication, conflict, impatience, intolerance of others, sense of being the "only one who can do the job"
- Behavioral
  - Calling out, arriving late, overwork, exhaustion, irresponsibility, poor follow-through

(Adapted from J. Yassen in Figley, 1995)

Slide 21

What is Self-Care?

Self-care is what people do for themselves to establish and maintain health, and to prevent and deal with illness.

It is a broad concept encompassing hygiene (general and personal), nutrition (type and quality of food eaten), lifestyle (sporting activities, leisure, etc.), environmental factors (living conditions, social habits, etc.) socio-economic factors (income level, cultural beliefs, etc.), and self-medication.'

(World Health Organization, 1998)

Slide 22

Resilience

Resilience is the process of **adapting** well in the face of adversity, trauma, tragedy, threats, or even significant sources of stress, such as family and relationship problems, serious health problems, or workplace and financial stressors.

It means "bouncing back" from difficult experiences.

(American Psychological Association)

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Vicarious resilience

Involves the process of learning about overcoming adversity from the trauma survivor and the resulting positive transformation and empowerment through their empathy and interaction.

(Hernandez, Gangsei, and Engstrom, 2007)

Slide 24

Impact of Vicarious Resilience

- Greater perspective and appreciation of own problems
- More optimistic, motivated, efficacious, and reenergized
- Increased sense of hope, understanding, and belief in the possibility of recovery from trauma and other serious challenges
- Profound sense of commitment to, and finding meaning from the work

(Hernandez, et al, 2007; Engstrom, et al, 2008)

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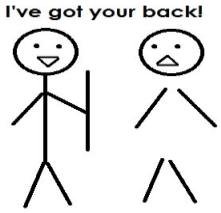
Acknowledging the Positive:

Compassion Satisfaction

Vicarious Transformation

Slide 26



Look out for one another

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